While discussing the increasing number of reptile encounters, someone had an idea. Why not bring in a predator that will take care of the snakes in a natural way? Peacocks, he explained, are known to keep the snake population under control. We learned that a TVS textile mill in the nearby Nanguneri town had been rearing peacocks for precisely the same reason. We decided to try it out.

We got five peacocks from the Nanguneri textile mill. Peacock being the national bird of India, it cannot be privately reared. But in this open forest, they could be brought in, but moving them from one location to another needed special permission from the union government. And ISRO had to give an undertaking that it would protect the bird from any human harm. Before setting them out in the open, we decided to keep the five peacocks in a large net enclosure. The peacocks soon became a major attraction to our scientists, workers and the occasional visitors from the government.

One morning, a worker came panting to me.

'They're gone!' he cried.

'What?' I did not understand what he meant.

'The peacocks are gone,' he repeated. 'Someone has cut open the nets and stolen the peacocks.'

I went to the enclosure. He was right, the net was damaged and someone had entered the enclosure. There were peacock feathers, suggesting some struggle. And then we saw the pug marks. A leopard had smelled out the new guests in Mahendragiri, and decided to have a sumptuous dinner. The bird we brought to prey on snakes, we realised, was the prey of leopards. The great food chain of nature.

Later we understood that the leopard could not feast on all the peacocks. It must have eaten one of them, the rest escaped into the nearby forests. Left to fend for itself, the peacocks must have adapted well. For, in a few years, peacocks, a species not seen in these parts, were often sighted. Today, visitors to Mahendragiri are likely to see the majestic bird in all its grandeur doing a rain dance. It may be debatable if the introduction of a species to a new habitat is advisable. Whatever be the ecologist's verdict, ISRO is